potential rapprochement with Beijing. The Chinese threat had not disappeared. Indian domestic intelligence officials worried about the increasing communications between China and Naga insurgents. Army officials downplayed the significance of these contacts, but Haksar and the cabinet and home secretaries shared the concern about the Naga insurgents' pattern of coming to and from China.[243] The October 1967 agreement for the construction of an all-weather road between Xinjiang and Pakistan-held Kashmir suggested to Delhi that Beijing had also dropped the pretense that the 1963 Sino-Pakistan understanding was "provisional."[244]

However, India's improved performance in the Sikkim skirmishes did give policymakers more confidence to signal to China that the door was open to negotiations. India made some informal overtures to China in 1967, but they had not been reciprocated or welcomed.[245] In spring 1968, Gandhi made a statement calling on China to establish better relations with states like India even if their governments had different political compositions.[246] In September 1968, India again called for talks with China. Such efforts served, if nothing else, to show the Afro-Asian world that India was not the intransigent country.[247] They also served notice to the Soviet Union in the aftermath of its military sales agreement with Pakistan. These efforts toward China continued, with the prime minister's office briefing Gandhi to state later that year, "We do not believe that one can proceed on the assumption of eternal animosity and conflict."[248]

Given the lack of response, the foreign ministry continued to be careful about any steps that might provoke China. For example, after Desai said in the US that he favored a two-China policy, the foreign ministry denied that this was official policy.[249] When Praja Socialist Party leader Jivatram Bhagwandas (J. B.) Kripalani proposed inviting a Taiwanese delegation for official Mahatma Gandhi centenary celebrations, Prime Minister Gandhi privately explained that "in the present strained relations between India and China, any pointed departure from the present practice might be treated by Peking as an affront to their sovereignty and provide them with an excuse for causing additional strain along our borders."[250] Then, when the Dalai Lama visited Delhi in November 1968 and requested meetings with the senior leadership, Haksar asked Gandhi to consider turning down his request to see her and the deputy prime minister. He also recommended that the defense minister should definitely not see the Dalai Lama.[251]